

# NatCen

Social Research that works for society



# British Social Attitudes 2022 User guide

At **NatCen Social Research** we believe that social research has the power to make life better. By really understanding the complexity of people's lives and what they think about the issues that affect them, we give the public a powerful and influential role in shaping decisions and services that can make a difference to everyone. And as an independent, not for profit organisation we're able to put all our time and energy into delivering social research that works for society.

---

NatCen Social Research  
35 Northampton Square  
London EC1V 0AX  
T 020 7250 1866  
[www.natcen.ac.uk](http://www.natcen.ac.uk)

A Company Limited by Guarantee  
Registered in England No.4392418.  
A Charity registered in England and Wales (1091768) and Scotland (SC038454)

---

# Contents.

|    |                                          |    |
|----|------------------------------------------|----|
| 1  | British Social Attitudes.....            | 5  |
| 2  | Accessing the data.....                  | 6  |
| 3  | What topics do the datasets cover? ..... | 7  |
| 4  | The sample .....                         | 9  |
|    | Selection of individuals .....           | 10 |
| 5  | Fieldwork.....                           | 11 |
|    | Advance mailings .....                   | 12 |
| 6. | Weighting the data .....                 | 13 |
| 7  | Analysing the data.....                  | 15 |
|    | Derived variables .....                  | 17 |
|    | Multi-code variables.....                | 22 |
|    | Open-ended questions .....               | 23 |
|    | Notes on other variables .....           | 23 |
|    | Further information .....                | 25 |

## Tables and Figures

|            |                                                                   |    |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| Table 3.1  | BSA 2022 Topics and corresponding funders .....                   | 7  |
| Table 4.1  | BSA 2022 Module versioning and number of achieved responses ..... | 9  |
| Table 5. 1 | BSA 2022 response rate.....                                       | 12 |
| Table 7.1  | Demographic variables.....                                        | 15 |
| Table 7.2  | Government office regions categories .....                        | 18 |

---

# 1 British Social Attitudes

The British Social Attitudes (BSA) survey has been running since 1983. During this time, we have surveyed almost 120,000 members of the public, each year asking up to 6,000 people up to 300 questions about their attitudes on a variety of topics ranging from welfare to genomic science. (Please note that the BSA did not take place in 1988 and 1992 due to the British Election Study series, which covered relevant attitudinal questions.)

BSA surveys inform the development of public policy and are an important barometer of public attitudes used by opinion leaders and social commentators. The topics covered in each survey are determined by the interests of our funders, therefore some questions have been asked every year, while others have been asked every couple of years or less frequently. Repeating some questions over time means that BSA is able to provide a unique insight into how social attitudes have changed during the last four decades.

Each year we publish a report, freely available online, using the data we have collected to present a compelling picture of Britain's social, moral and political attitudes. Our latest report based on data collected in 2021 is our 39th Report: [www.bsa.natcen.ac.uk](http://www.bsa.natcen.ac.uk).

---

## 2 Accessing the data

Users from non-commercial organisations can download the data directly from the UK Data Service (UKDS). Access to the data requires OpenAthens registration. You can download the data as SPSS, STATA, or TAB files. Data is archived around a year after the completion of fieldwork (giving time for analysis and reporting).

Commercial organisations must notify the National Centre for Social Research by email ([BSA@natcen.ac.uk](mailto:BSA@natcen.ac.uk)) stating their intended use and seeking permission for download. Permission to download may incur a charge. UKDS will be monitoring usage and providing NatCen with usage reports.

### 3 What topics do the datasets cover?

From 2020, due to the pandemic, the British Social Attitudes has been administered with a mixed-mode design of web and CATI (telephone interviews), with no face-to-face interviews as in previous years. Questions from previous rounds, as well as new modules were adapted for web and telephone interviewing.

The table below shows the range of topics the survey covered in 2022:

**Table 3.1 BSA 2022 Topics and corresponding funders**

| Topic                                            | Funder                           |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Employment                                       | NatCen Social Research           |
| Politics                                         | NatCen Social Research           |
| Benefits and income                              | NatCen Social Research           |
| National identity and ethnicity                  | NatCen Social Research           |
| Religion                                         | NatCen Social Research           |
| Disability                                       | NatCen Social Research           |
| Education                                        | NatCen Social Research           |
| <b>Unfunded module</b>                           |                                  |
| Changing identities                              | NatCen Social Research           |
| Women in work                                    | NatCen Social Research           |
| Impact of women's work on families               | NatCen Social Research           |
| Gender and chores distributions in the household | NatCen Social Research           |
| Marriage, families and sexual relationships      | NatCen Social Research           |
| Role of the government                           | NatCen Social Research           |
| Nuclear defence                                  | NatCen Social Research           |
| Nuclear power and the environment                | NatCen Social Research           |
| <b>Welfare module</b>                            |                                  |
| Housing                                          | Department for Work and Pensions |
| Work and health                                  | Department for Work and Pensions |
| Digital                                          | Department for Work and Pensions |
| Pensions and retirement                          | Department for Work and Pensions |
| Poverty                                          | Department for Work and Pensions |
| Fraud and error                                  | Department for Work and Pensions |
| <b>Equalities and social class module</b>        |                                  |
| Sexual relationships                             | Government Equalities Office     |
| Parental leave                                   | Government Equalities Office     |
| Disability, mental health and the workplace      | Government Equalities Office     |
| Social mobility                                  | Government Equalities Office     |
| Social class                                     | Government Equalities Office     |
| <b>Health and Social Care module</b>             |                                  |
| Satisfaction with health and care services       | King's Fund & Nuffield Trust     |
| Health and care spending                         | King's Fund & Nuffield Trust     |
| NHS priorities and principles                    | King's Fund & Nuffield Trust     |
| <b>Emergency Care and Treatment Plan module</b>  | University of Warwick            |
| <b>Attitudes to breastfeeding module</b>         | University of Reading            |

---

A wide range of background and classificatory questions are also always included. A number of the same questions are asked most years, enabling us to track change over time.



## 4 The sample

In 2022 the sample for the British Social Attitudes survey was split into 12 versions. The table below illustrates the modules, their corresponding versions and the number of complete and partial responses achieved.

**Table 4.1 BSA 2022 Module versioning and number of achieved responses**

| Module                                      | V1 | V2 | V3 | V4 | V5 | V6 | V7 | V8 | V9 | V10 | V11 | V12 | Responses achieved              |
|---------------------------------------------|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|-----|-----|-----|---------------------------------|
| Classification                              |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 6,679 completes and 20 partials |
| DWP                                         |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,301 completes and 9 partials  |
| Health & Social Care <sup>1</sup>           |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 1,184 completes and 3 partials  |
| Emergency Care & Treatment Plans            |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 1,132 completes and 3 partials  |
| Breastfeeding                               |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,194 completes and 8 partials  |
| Social Class                                |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,740 completes and 7 partials  |
| National Identity                           |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,320 completes and 6 partials  |
| Women in work                               |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,320 completes and 6 partials  |
| Impact on Family                            |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,320 completes and 6 partials  |
| Gender and chores <sup>2</sup>              |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 1,061 completes and 5 partials  |
| Marriage, families and sexual relationships |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,233 completes and 6 partials  |
| Moral issues                                |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 1,136 completes and 3 partials  |
| Role of the Government                      |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 2,740 completes and 7 partials  |
| Civil and Nuclear                           |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 1,049 completes and 3 partials  |
| Equalities                                  |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |     |     |     | 3,378 completes and 11 partials |

<sup>1</sup> Three questions were also included in version 7-10

<sup>2</sup> One question (Choreshr) was also asked on versions 3-4

---

BSA is designed to yield a representative sample of adults aged 18 or over. Since 1993, the sampling frame for the survey has been the **Postcode Address File (PAF)**, which is a list of addresses (or postal delivery points) compiled by the Post Office. For practical reasons, the sample is confined to those living in private households. Both people living in institutions and households whose addresses are not on the PAF are excluded.

A sample file of non-clustered addresses was produced from the PAF. Addresses located North of the Caledonian Canal and on the Isles of Scilly were excluded from both the clustered and non-clustered sample for consistency with previous years of BSA. The sample file was then split into a main sample and two reserve samples. 44,280 total addresses were then allocated to a main sample (N= 36,900) and a reserve sample (n=7,380). The reserve sample was not issued in 2022.

The Multiple-Occupancy Indicator (MOI) available through PAF was used when selecting addresses in Scotland. The MOI indicates the number of dwelling units at an individual address. If the MOI indicated more than one dwelling unit at a given address, the probability of the address being selected from the list of addresses would increase so that it matched the total number of dwelling units. The MOI is largely irrelevant in England and Wales, as separate dwelling units (DUs) generally appear as separate entries on PAF. In Scotland, tenements with many flats tend to appear as one entry on PAF. However, even in Scotland, 99.9% of the MOIs in the sample had a value of one. The remainder had MOIs greater than one. The MOI affects the selection probability of the address, so it was necessary to incorporate an adjustment for this into the weighting procedures (described below).

## Selection of individuals

Up to two individuals aged 18 or over living at the selected addresses were eligible to take part. The invitation and reminder letters contained two unique access codes allowing any two adults aged 18+ living within the household to log in and complete the questionnaire.

---

## 5 Fieldwork

Fieldwork was carried out between 7<sup>th</sup> September and 30<sup>th</sup> October 2022.

Fieldwork used a mixed-mode design, offering the choice of both web and telephone survey completion. The fieldwork period was the same for both modes. The invitation and first reminder letters sent to respondents encouraged participants to take part online, while giving them the option to take part by phone if they wanted to. The letter and first reminder emphasised the option to take part by web. The second reminder letter made the option to take part by phone more explicit.

Telephone fieldwork was conducted by interviewers drawn from NatCen Social Research's regular panel. Before fieldwork began, interviewers attended a briefing conference to familiarise themselves with the questionnaire. A total of 136 interviews were conducted via phone and 6,563 interviews were completed via web.

The mean interview length for each version of the questionnaire was:

|            |                       |
|------------|-----------------------|
| Version 1  | 30 minutes,48 seconds |
| Version 2  | 30 minutes,52 seconds |
| Version 3  | 30 minutes,35 seconds |
| Version 4  | 30 minutes,13 seconds |
| Version 5  | 31 minutes,41 seconds |
| Version 6  | 32 minutes,14 seconds |
| Version 7  | 35 minutes,36 seconds |
| Version 8  | 35 minutes,07 seconds |
| Version 9  | 33 minutes,48 seconds |
| Version 10 | 34 minutes,04 seconds |
| Version 11 | 34 minutes,59 seconds |
| Version 12 | 33 minutes,38 seconds |

Overall, we achieved a household response rate of between 13.0% and 14.2%. Details are shown in Table 5.1.

| Table 5. 1 BSA 2022 response rate                                |                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Issued sample                                                    | 73,800 cases<br>36,900 addresses |
| Estimate number of deadwood/ineligible <sup>3</sup>              | 10%                              |
| Eligible addresses                                               | 33,210                           |
| Number of fully productive cases                                 | 6,638                            |
| Number of partially productive cases                             | 271                              |
| Number of addresses with at least one complete (full or partial) | 4,831                            |
| Number of completes per address                                  | 1.43                             |
| Unadjusted household response rate                               | 13%                              |
| Adjusted household response rate                                 | 14.5%                            |

## Advance mailings

Sampled addresses were sent an advance letter on the 6th of September, inviting adults aged 18 or over and resident at the household to take part in the survey. Up to two adults could take part in each household. Participants had the option to complete the survey via web or telephone. Non-responsive households were sent two reminder letters, which included the access codes for the web survey and the BSA contact number. A £10 voucher was issued upon completion and sent out to the respondents via email or post.

---

<sup>3</sup> Estimate based on BSA 2019 % of ineligible

---

## 6. Weighting the data

As with previous waves of the BSA, weights have been constructed to adjust for differential non-response. The change in methodology from “face-to-face” to “push-to-web” meant that non-response could occur within households as well as at the level of the address. This contrasts with previous years where one adult was selected at random at each address, and selection weights were used to account for differential selection probabilities.

As described in section four, addresses were selected with equal probability, and up to two people in one household at each address were invited to take part. Weighting was therefore required to adjust for non-response *within* households in addition to accounting for non-response amongst households at selected addresses. Separate non-response models were constructed to deal with each of these elements of non-response. Finally, calibration weighting was used to adjust the profile of the responding sample to match the population in terms of age, sex, education, tenure, ethnicity, economic activity and region.

To minimise non-response bias, data should be weighted in all univariate analyses. Weighting is also recommended for multivariate analysis. The file is not pre-weighted: before running any analysis, please “switch on” the NatCen computed weight (**BSA22\_final\_wt**).

Only one weight is available this year. Due to the change in method, there is no selection weight (see above) and no separate self-completion weight (as the majority of responses were entirely from self-completion on the web).

### Non-response models

It is known that certain subgroups in the population are more likely to respond to surveys than others. These groups can end up over-represented in the responding sample, which can lead to bias in the survey estimates. Given that up to two people per household could respond this year, non-response can occur at the household level, where no one from the selected address responds, or within households, where only one person responds in households with two or more adults. Where information is available about non-responding addresses, propensity for households (at selected addresses) to respond can be modelled, and the results used to generate a non-response weight. Similarly, where information is available about responding households, the expected number of responses within these households can also be modelled. Hence, this year there are two non-response weights for households – one for between household non-response and one for within household non-response. These are intended to reduce bias in the responding sample resulting from differential response to the survey.

Between household response was modelled using logistic regression, with the dependent variable indicating whether or not someone at each selected address responded to the survey. A number of area-level variables, including aggregated census data and deprivation indices were considered for modeling response. From this

---

model, the between household non-response weight was calculated as the inverse of the predicted response probability for each responding household.

Within household response was also modelled using logistic regression, with the dependent variable indicating whether each responding address had one or two responses to the survey. Single-adult addresses and non-responding addresses were not included in this stage of non-response modelling. As well as the area-level information used before, additional household-level variables such as household size, tenure, whether anyone in the household has a degree and income were also considered. The predicted probability from the model was used to estimate the expected number of completed surveys in responding households. This was calculated as  $1 \times (1-p) + 2 \times p = 1+p$ , where  $p$  is the probability of two responses. The within household non-response weight was calculated as the ratio of the number of adults in the household (capped at 4) divided by the expected number of responses for each responding household, i.e.  $\text{numad} / (1+p)$ , where  $\text{numad}$  is the number of adults in the household (capped at 4).

The composite (pre-calibration) weight was calculated as the product of the two non-response weights above.

### **Calibration weighting**

In the final stage of weighting, calibration was used to adjust the composite non-response weight (from the previous stages) so that the weighted sample was in line with the best available population estimates of GB adults for: sex by age, region, education by age, ethnicity and housing tenure.

Population estimates were obtained from the 2020 mid-year population estimates published by the Office for National Statistics/General Register Office for Scotland (for age, sex and region) and the latest Labour Force Survey (for education, ethnicity and housing tenure). These are the most recent estimates at the time of weighting.

The final calibrated weight (**BSA22\_final\_wt**) has been scaled to the responding sample size. It should be used for all analyses of BSA 2022.

## 7 Analysing the data

BSA provides a compelling account of the public's economic, political, moral and social attitudes over a 40-year period. It can be used to either provide an annual snapshot of the public's attitudes through an analysis of a single dataset or to create a narrative of the public's attitudes over a period of time by analysing several datasets.

Several questions have been repeated over the years. The original variable names have been retained except in the cases where the question wording has been changed. Questions have been optimised for web and telephone modes, as per 2020 and 2021. The 2022 survey data used very similar methods to 2020 and 2021, so comparisons can be made here however caution is needed when presenting findings from BSA 2022 alongside survey years before year 2020, as differences between years may be due to the change in survey mode.

Please note that the data must be weighted in all analysis. The file is not pre-weighted. Before conducting any form of analysis, the data must be weighted using the NatCen computed weight (BSA22\_final\_wt). As long as the weight is included when specifying the sample design, the complex sample procedures will ensure that the data is weighted; however, other procedures may not weight the data automatically.

Versions 1 to 12 are geographically unclustered. When using complex sample procedures we would recommend using region (GOR) as the stratification variable, and household serial (PSU) as the cluster variable. Up to two people in each household are able to take part in the survey so the sample is clustered at the household level.

Unlike some other surveys, on British Social Attitudes responses of 'Don't know' or 'Prefer not to answer' are considered to be valid responses and should be included in the base for analysis.

There are a number of identification variables that users may find useful in analyses. These are listed below. In addition, there are a number of potentially useful derived variables that are outlined in the following section.

**Table 7.1 Demographic variables**

|            |                                                |
|------------|------------------------------------------------|
| DVSex21    | Respondent's sex                               |
| RAgeCat    | Respondent's age group                         |
| RaceOri4   | Respondent's ethnicity                         |
| ReligSum22 | Respondent's religion                          |
| REarn      | Total gross individual income                  |
| HEdQual2   | Respondent's highest educational qualification |

|          |                             |
|----------|-----------------------------|
| MarStat6 | Respondent's marital status |
| Tenure   | Respondent's tenure         |



|            |                                                 |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| ReconAct20 | Respondent's economic activity (priority coded) |
| HhIAdGpd   | Number of adults in household (grouped)         |
| HhIChIGpd  | Number of children in household (grouped)       |
| BestNatu2  | Nationality that best describes the respondent  |

---

## Derived variables

The BSA dataset contains derived variables (DVs), which were computed post-fieldwork for the purpose of analysis. See below for further information on DVs provided in BSA's dataset is below..

### Age

RAgeCat is a dv comprised of seven age groups: 18-24, 25-34, 35-44, 45-54, 55-59, 60-64 and 65+. It is based on responses provided for RespAge (a question asked to all respondents) and Ragebnd (a question that collected banded age from respondents who refused to answer RespAge).

### Gender

This variable categories respondent's gender into male, female and 'other gender identity' based on their responses at the question asking whether their gender is the same as their sex as registered on their birth certificate.

### Disability and effect on daily life

This variable splits respondents into three categories: i) they have a disability which affects their daily life ii) they have a disability but it doesn't affect their daily life and they don't have a disability. The DV is computed using variables Disact2 and Disnew3.

### Region

The dataset includes a region variable [GOR], which categorises cases into 14 regions, formerly the Government Office Regions. [GOR] combines Inner London and Outer London into one region. Earlier datasets between 2003–2016 use GOR2 (although GOR\_ID is also available); from 2000-2002 the equivalent variable was [GOR]. Before 2000, (1983–1999) [StRegion] was the variable denoting region. It should be noted that the coding of these variables are not the same, and that [GOR2] splits London into 'outer' and 'inner'. Users should be aware of potentially small sample sizes for regional subgroups, and the implications that has for analysis.

**Table 7.2 Government office regions categories**

| <b>Code</b> | <b>StRegion<br/>(1983–1999)</b>   | <b>GOR<br/>(2000–2002)</b> | <b>GOR2<br/>(2003–2016)</b> | <b>GOR_ID<br/>(2017-2020)</b> | <b>GOR</b>               |
|-------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 1           | Scotland                          | North East                 | North East                  | North East                    | North East               |
| 2           | North of England                  | North West                 | North West                  | North West                    | North West               |
| 3           | North West                        | Merseyside                 | Yorkshire and the Humber    | Yorkshire and the Humber      | Yorkshire and the Humber |
| 4           | Yorks and Humberside              | Yorkshire & Humber         | East Midlands               | East Midlands                 | East Midlands            |
| 5           | West Midlands                     | East Midlands              | West Midlands               | West Midlands                 | West Midlands            |
| 6           | East Midlands                     | West Midlands              | East of England             | East of England               | East of England          |
| 7           | East Anglia                       | South West                 | Inner London                | London                        | London                   |
| 8           | South West                        | East of England            | Outer London                | South East                    | South East               |
| 9           | South East (excl. Greater London) | South East                 | South East                  | South West                    | South West               |
| 10          | Greater London                    | London                     | South West                  | Wales                         | Wales                    |
| 11          | Wales                             | Wales                      | Wales                       | Scotland                      | Scotland                 |
| 12          |                                   | Scotland                   | Scotland                    |                               | Northern Ireland         |
| 13          |                                   |                            |                             |                               | Channel Islands          |
| 14          |                                   |                            |                             |                               | Isle of Man              |

---

## Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) and National Statistics Socio-Economic Classification

Respondents are classified according to their own occupation, not that of the 'head of household'. Therefore, respondents were asked about their current or last job, so that all respondents except those who have never worked were coded. Just as in 2021, for the 2022 survey respondents were asked to self-code their current or last job into an 8 category variable (EmpOCC). An employment status that captures information on employment status and supervisory status has also been derived (EmployB) based on REconAct and REconFW.

An employment status variable that captures information on employment status and size of organisation was also derived (EmplStatDV) based on questions collect information on whether an individual is:

- an employer, self-employed or an employee (EMPSTAT);
- size of organisation (employ); and
- supervisory status (Superv).

The National Statistics Socio-Economic Classification (NS-SEC) was derived from a combination of information on occupation and employment status. In the dataset this variable is called 'RClassGP'. It is important to note this difference how the NS-SEC variable was derived this year, and to take this into account when comparing findings from previous survey years.

For some analyses, it may be more appropriate to classify respondents according to their current socio-economic status, which takes into account only their present economic position. Respondents can be allocated to one of the following categories: "in full time education/training", "in work, waiting to take up work", "in paid work but furloughed", "on maternity or paternity leave", "unemployed", "retired" or "other" using the data recorded at REconsum20.

### Note on analysing changing attitudes by social class over time

When analysing how the attitudes of different social classes have changed over time, you need to use a variable that gives a comparable measure of social class across the lifetime of the survey (during which class has been measured using a range of different variables). There is no perfect solution, but our strong preference is to use Goldthorpe-Heath (5 category version) class – RGHClass – before the 2000 SOC became a standard feature of the survey in 2000, and NS-SEC analytic class – RNSEG – thereafter. At the 5-class level these two schemes are conceptually based on more or less the same principles. (You can only do this going back to 1987.) For **BSA 2016 and later years** a variable RNSEGD has been included in the data set which bands RNSEG into 5 categories. Before 2016, a 5-category variable can be derived using RNSEG and the following syntax.

---

**For BSA 2001 up until BSA 2015 use: RNSEGD (derived as below)**

RECODE RNSEG (1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 = 1) (9 = 2) (3, 15, 16, 17 = 3) (11, 12 = 4) (10, 13, 14, 18 = 5) (else = sysmis) into RNSEGD.

Execute.

Variable labels RNSEGD "RNSEG compressed".

Value labels RNSEGD

- 1 "Salaried (Higher & Lower)"
- 2 "Clerical (Junior non-manual)"
- 3 "Petty Bourgeois"
- 4 "Foremen/Technicians"
- 5 "Working class"
- 99 "Don't know".

**For BSA 2000 and earlier years use: RGHClass (1983 Heath Goldthorpe scale)**

RECODE **RGHClass** (1 thru 2 = 1) (3 thru 4 = 2) (5 thru 7 = 3) (8 = 4) (9 thru 11 = 5) (else = sysmis) into RGHClassD.

Execute.

Variable labels RGHClassD "RGHClass compressed".

Value labels RGHClassD

- 1 "Professional / managerial"
- 2 "Routine"
- 3 "Small petty bourgeoisie / farmers"
- 4 "Manual"
- 5 "Other manual"
- 99 "Don't know".

## Income

The BSA dataset includes a standard measure of household income [HHIncome]. This year, respondents were asked to place themselves into banded income quartiles. The bandings used are designed to be representative of those that exist in Britain and are taken from the Family Resources Survey (see <http://research.dwp.gov.uk/asd/frs>). REarn asked respondents currently in work to place themselves within estimated earnings quartiles.

## Attitude scales

Since 1986, the British Social Attitudes surveys have included two attitude scales which aim to measure where respondents stand on certain underlying value dimensions: left–right and libertarian–authoritarian. Since 1987 (except in 1990), a similar scale on ‘welfarism’ has also been included. Some of the items in the welfarism scale were changed in 2000–2001. The current version of the scale is shown below. A useful way of summarising the information from a number of questions of this sort is to construct an additive index (Spector, 1992; DeVellis, 2003). This approach rests on the assumption that there is an underlying – ‘latent’ – attitudinal dimension which characterises the answers to all the questions within each scale. If so, scores on the index are likely to be a more reliable indication of the underlying attitude than the answers to any one question.

---

Each of these scales consists of a number of statements to which the respondent is invited to “agree strongly”, “agree”, “neither agree nor disagree”, “disagree” or “disagree strongly”. The items are:

### Left–right scale (5 items)

*Government should redistribute income from the better off to those who are less well off.* [Redistrb]

*Big business benefits owners at the expense of workers.* [BigBusnN]

*Ordinary working people do not get their fair share of the nation’s wealth.* [Wealth]

*There is one law for the rich and one for the poor.* [RichLaw]

*Management will always try to get the better of employees if it gets the chance.* [Indust4]

### Libertarian–authoritarian scale (6 items)

*Young people today don’t have enough respect for traditional British values.* [TradVals]

*People who break the law should be given stiffer sentences.* [StifSent]

*For some crimes, the death penalty is the most appropriate sentence.* [DeathApp]

*Schools should teach children to obey authority.* [Obey]

*The law should always be obeyed, even if a particular law is wrong.* [WrongLaw]

*Censorship of films and magazines is necessary to uphold moral standards.* [Censor]

### Welfarism scale (8 items)

*The welfare state encourages people to stop helping each other.* [WelfHelp]

*The government should spend more money on welfare benefits for the poor, even if it leads to higher taxes.* [MoreWelf]

*Around here, most unemployed people could find a job if they really wanted one.* [UnempJob]

*Many people who get social security don’t really deserve any help.* [SocHelp]

---

*Most people on the dole are fiddling in one way or another.* [DoleFidl]

*If welfare benefits weren't so generous, people would learn to stand on their own two feet.* [WelfFeet]

*Cutting welfare benefits would damage too many people's lives.*  
[DamLives]

*The creation of the welfare state is one of Britain's proudest achievements.*  
[ProudWif]

The indices for the three scales are formed by scoring the leftmost, most libertarian or most pro-welfare position, as 1 and the rightmost, most authoritarian or most anti-welfarist position, as 5. The “neither agree nor disagree” option is scored as 3. All the items in the libauth scale have been reversed coded as well as items Unemjob to Welfhelp on the welfare scale.

The scores to all the questions in each scale are added and then divided by the number of items in the scale, giving indices ranging from 1 (leftmost, most libertarian, most pro-welfare) to 5 (rightmost, most authoritarian, most anti-welfare).

Items that were coded as “Don't know” or “refusals” in the individual scale items were recoded as 3 (mid-point value of the scale) if the number of valid items was three or more in the left-right (total = 5 items) and libertarian-authoritarian scale (total = 6 items) and five or more in the welfare scale (total = 8 items). If the number of valid items was lower than those specified (and therefore there was a greater number of “don't know”/ “refusals” (thus preventing us to derive a scale score), the scale value for those individuals was set to “missing” and given a code of 9. If a user wishes to look at average scores they will need to declare these values as ‘missing’.

The scores on the three indices have been placed on the dataset.

The scales were tested for reliability (as measured by Cronbach's alpha) using the BSA 2022 data. The Cronbach's alpha (unstandardised items) for the scales in 2022 were 0.84 for the left-right scale, 0.89 for the welfarism scale and 0.80 for the libertarian authoritarian scale. This level of reliability can generally be considered ‘good’ for the left-right, welfare scales and the libertarian authoritarian scale (DeVellis, 2003: 95–96)

## Multi-code variables

There are some survey questions that allowed respondents to provide more than one response. In this case, binary variables were created for each response option available. These binary variables record the number of respondents who chose that response option. If a respondent answered “don't know” or “refused” to a multi-code question, the “don't know” or “prefer not to answer” response has been included at each of the binary variables.

## Open-ended questions

Questions that had an “Other – Please specify” option have been back-coded into the questions’ existing categories. Where the answers in the free-text did not fit into any of the existing categories new categories have been created if a sufficient number of responses could be grouped in that category; otherwise responses have been coded as “Other specific answer not in code-frame”.

The following variables were coded:

|             |            |
|-------------|------------|
| betlife     | relrhw     |
| choresid    | repwho     |
| ear5wfw     | rspgndr    |
| hedqual2    | scoport    |
| hincdif4    | srsoccl1   |
| inforet3    | tenhhl     |
| lat5wh2     | whendid    |
| legstat3    | whenplan   |
| maininc5    | whodid     |
| natidgb     | whoplan    |
| nationu     | whycaresat |
| nhspriority | whydissat  |
| partyfw     | whydis     |
| raceori3    | whynrep    |
| reconfw     | whysat     |
| relffw      |            |

## Notes on other variables

**BNationU** is a follow-up question to NationU which is a multi-coded question that asks people what nationality they identify as. This question also contains an open-response option “Other” asking people to specify their nationality if not included in any of the response options. This open question has been back-coded. BNationU asks people to select the option that *best* describes their nationality and this year it will pull in the back-coded response from NationU. This does not appear to have been done in previous year, and the “Other” category was presented in its raw form rather than taking into account that NationU has been back-coded. We believe this will provide a



---

more precise presentation of the data , however it does mean that the question may be slightly different from previous years and not directly comparable.

---

## Further information

For further information on anything contained in this booklet please contact:

[bsa@natcen.ac.uk](mailto:bsa@natcen.ac.uk)